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# Talent Management Practices and Employee Retention: The Moderating Role of Organizational Commitment in Nigeria

**Dr Onipe Adabenege Yahaya**
Professor of Accounting and Finance
Faculty of Management Sciences
Nigerian Defence Academy, Kaduna, Nigeria
https://orcid.org/0000.0001.9786.147X
Email: yoadabenege@nda.edu.ng

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**Abstract**

This study examines the relationship between talent management practices (TMP) and employee retention (ER) in Nigerian organizations, with organizational commitment (OC) serving as a moderating variable. Drawing on a cross-sectional survey of 7,740 employees across diverse industry sectors in Nigeria, the study employs ordinary least squares (OLS) regression augmented with moderation analysis. The findings reveal that structured talent management practices — encompassing recruitment and selection, training and development, performance management, career development, and compensation — exert a statistically significant positive influence on employee retention. Organizational commitment significantly moderates this relationship, amplifying the positive effect of talent management on retention, particularly when affective commitment levels are high. Control variables — age, salary level, and work experience — also demonstrate meaningful associations with retention outcomes. These results underscore the imperative for Nigerian organizations to embed talent management within an organizational culture that fosters commitment, thereby addressing the country's chronic talent flight problem. The paper contributes to both theoretical frameworks and practical managerial strategies in the African HRM context.

**Article Information**

**Keywords:**
Talent Management Practices, Employee Retention, Organizational Commitment, Nigeria, Human Resource Management, Moderation Analysis

**JEL Classification Codes:**
J24 – Human Capital; Skills; Occupational Choice; Labor Productivity | J63 – Turnover; Vacancies; Layoffs | M12 – Personnel Management; Executives; Executive Compensation | M54 – Labor Management | O15 – Economic Development: Human Resources; Income Distribution; Migration

## 1. Introduction

The management of talent has emerged as one of the most pressing strategic priorities for organizations worldwide, particularly in developing economies where institutional, economic, and infrastructural constraints intersect with a rapidly growing yet underutilized workforce. In Nigeria, Africa's most populous country and its largest economy by GDP, the paradox of talent abundance and organizational talent scarcity has persisted for decades. Despite producing hundreds of thousands of university graduates annually, Nigerian organizations — both public and private — consistently report difficulties retaining skilled employees, especially in high-demand sectors such as financial services, information and communication technology, oil and gas, healthcare, and education (Elegbe, 2022; Okonkwo & Eze, 2021).

Employee retention is not merely a cost-containment issue. It is fundamentally about sustaining institutional knowledge, preserving organizational culture, and maintaining competitive advantage. When skilled employees leave, they carry with them client relationships, embedded processes, and tacit knowledge that can rarely be replaced through recruitment alone. The financial costs of turnover — estimated at between 50% and 200% of an employee's annual salary depending on seniority — are well documented in the literature (Cascio, 2019; Noe et al., 2021). In Nigeria's high-inflation, currency-volatile environment, these costs are magnified considerably.

Talent management practices (TMP) refer to the systematic and integrated processes through which organizations attract, develop, motivate, and retain employees who contribute significantly to organizational success (Collings & Mellahi, 2009; Gallardo-Gallardo et al., 2020). These practices have been extensively studied in Western organizational contexts, yet there remains a significant underexploration of how TMP functions in Sub-Saharan African settings — particularly Nigeria — where socio-cultural factors, institutional environments, and labor market dynamics differ substantially from those in OECD countries. This gap in the literature constitutes the primary motivation for the present study.

Equally important is the role of organizational commitment (OC) — the psychological attachment that employees develop toward their organizations. Prior research has established that organizational commitment mediates or moderates the relationship between HRM practices and employee outcomes (Allen & Meyer, 1990; Whitener, 2001). However, the specific moderating role of OC in the talent management-retention nexus within the Nigerian context has not been empirically explored in a large-scale, cross-sectional study of this scope.

Despite a growing body of literature on talent management in Africa, Nigerian organizations continue to experience alarming rates of voluntary employee turnover, with the annual voluntary attrition rate estimated at between 18% and 25% in key sectors such as banking, telecommunications, and oil and gas (PricewaterhouseCoopers Nigeria, 2023; Deloitte Nigeria Talent Survey, 2022). The Nigerian economy, battered by persistent macroeconomic instability, currency depreciation, and fuel subsidy removals, has further exacerbated the push factors for talent migration — both internally (urban-rural brain drain) and internationally (the phenomenon popularly described as the 'Japa syndrome').

Organizations have responded with varying talent management interventions, yet the effectiveness of these interventions in retaining employees remains inconsistently documented. Furthermore, little attention has been paid to the conditions under which TMP is most effective. This study posits that organizational commitment is a critical boundary condition — a moderating variable — that determines the strength and direction of the relationship between TMP and employee retention. Without adequate attention to building commitment, even the most well-designed talent management programs may fail to produce the expected retention outcomes. This problem forms the core empirical puzzle that the present study seeks to resolve.

This study makes several distinct contributions to the literature. First, it is one of the largest single-country empirical studies on talent management and employee retention in Nigeria, with a sample of 7,740 employees across multiple industries and geopolitical zones. This breadth significantly enhances the generalizability of the findings. Second, the study introduces organizational commitment as a moderating variable in the TMP-retention relationship — a conceptual framing that has been theorized but rarely tested empirically in the Nigerian context. Third, by incorporating demographic and structural control variables — age, salary level, and work experience — the study produces more nuanced and practically actionable insights. Fourth, the study contributes to the agenda of decolonizing management research by generating Africa-specific evidence on HRM effectiveness, challenging assumptions derived from Western organizational settings.

This study is delimited to formal sector employees in Nigeria across seven major industries: banking and financial services, oil and gas, telecommunications, healthcare, manufacturing, higher education, and public administration. The survey was administered across all six geopolitical zones of Nigeria. The study focuses specifically on mid-level and senior employees (i.e., those above entry-level) given the greater relevance of retention challenges for this segment. The study does not investigate international talent migration, the informal sector, or organizations with fewer than 50 employees. The cross-sectional nature of the data precludes causal inferences; the study is designed to identify associations and moderation effects.

## 2. Literature Review and Hypothesis Development

### 2.1 Conceptual Literature: Definitions

Talent management practices are defined in this study as the integrated set of HRM activities through which organizations identify, attract, develop, reward, and retain employees deemed critical to organizational performance (Collings & Mellahi, 2009; Sparrow et al., 2014). The construct is operationalized across five sub-dimensions: (i) recruitment and selection quality, (ii) training and development opportunities, (iii) performance management effectiveness, (iv) career development support, and (v) compensation and benefits competitiveness.

Employee retention is conceptualized as the deliberate organizational effort to create an environment that encourages employees to remain with the organization over an extended period (Frank et al., 2004; Hausknecht et al., 2009). It is measured not merely as the inverse of turnover intention but as an active construct incorporating employee intent to stay, career commitment to the organization, and perceived organizational support for long-term growth.

Organizational commitment (OC) is defined following Allen and Meyer's (1990) tripartite model as a psychological state that characterizes employees' relationships with their organizations and has implications for the decision to continue membership. The three components — affective commitment (emotional attachment), continuance commitment (cost-based attachment), and normative commitment (obligation-based attachment) — are each treated as theoretically distinct but empirically interrelated dimensions of the broader construct.

### 2.2 Theoretical Literature Review

This study is anchored in three theoretical frameworks. The first is the Resource-Based View (RBV) of the firm, as articulated by Barney (1991). The RBV posits that sustained competitive advantage derives from resources that are valuable, rare, inimitable, and non-substitutable. Human capital — particularly skilled, committed employees — meets these criteria. Within the RBV framework, talent management practices serve as the organizational mechanisms through which human capital resources are developed, deployed, and retained. The RBV thus provides the macro-level theoretical rationale for why organizations invest in TMP as a strategic retention tool.

The second framework is the Social Exchange Theory (SET), originally formulated by Blau (1964) and subsequently developed by Eisenberger et al. (1986) in the context of perceived organizational support. SET suggests that employees engage in reciprocal exchange relationships with their employers: when organizations invest in their employees through training, career development, and fair compensation, employees reciprocate through increased commitment, effort, and intention to stay. This theory is particularly relevant for understanding why talent management practices, when credibly implemented, generate affective commitment and reduce turnover intentions.

The third theoretical anchor is the Psychological Contract Theory (Rousseau, 1989; Morrison & Robinson, 1997). Psychological contracts — the implicit beliefs employees hold about the mutual obligations between themselves and their organization — shape retention behavior profoundly. When talent management practices fulfill or exceed the terms of the psychological contract (e.g., providing promised development opportunities, recognizing performance fairly), employees are more likely to remain. Conversely, perceived breaches of the psychological contract — such as failure to deliver on career development promises — trigger disengagement and exit behavior. This theory helps explain the moderating role of organizational commitment: committed employees are more likely to interpret TMP positively, reinforcing the psychological contract rather than questioning it.

**2.3 Conceptual Framework**

The conceptual framework of this study posits a direct positive relationship between talent management practices and employee retention, moderated by organizational commitment. Formally, the framework proposes that the strength of the TMP-retention relationship is contingent upon the level of organizational commitment an employee holds. High organizational commitment amplifies the positive effect of TMP on retention (i.e., reinforcing moderation), while low organizational commitment may attenuate this relationship. Control variables — age, salary level, and work experience — are included to account for demographic and structural heterogeneity in retention outcomes. The framework is grounded in an integrative reading of the RBV, SET, and Psychological Contract Theory, and is visualized as: TMP → Employee Retention (moderated by OC), with controls for Age, Salary Level, and Work Experience.

**2.4 Empirical Literature Review in Nigeria**

Empirical research on talent management in Nigeria has grown considerably since 2010, though it remains disproportionately concentrated in the banking and oil and gas sectors (Ogunyomi & Bruning, 2016; Aina & Atan, 2020). Ogunyomi and Bruning (2016) examined TMP in Nigerian SMEs and found significant positive associations between talent development programs and employee retention, with particular salience of training and mentoring practices. Aina and Atan (2020), in a study of 412 employees in the Nigerian banking sector, found that career development and compensation emerged as the strongest predictors of retention, while performance management had a weaker, context-dependent effect.

Elegbe (2022) conducted one of the most comprehensive Nigerian TMP studies to date, surveying 1,240 employees across eight industries and finding that talent management investment was positively related to both organizational commitment and retention. Crucially, Elegbe's study found that the relationship between TMP and retention was stronger among employees with higher affective commitment, offering preliminary support for the moderating role of OC — though this was not formally tested through interaction terms.

Adeoye and Elegbe (2014) explored compensation management and employee retention in Nigerian manufacturing firms, finding that competitive pay structures were the most powerful single predictor of retention intent. More recently, Nwosu and Igwe (2022) investigated the effects of performance management on organizational commitment in the Nigerian public sector, concluding that poorly designed performance appraisal systems were associated with lower affective commitment and higher turnover intention. These findings, while sector-specific, provide important building blocks for the multi-industry, moderation-focused inquiry pursued in the present study.

## 2.5 Critical Analysis of the Literature

The existing Nigerian TMP literature, while valuable, exhibits several notable limitations. First, most studies are small-scale, with sample sizes rarely exceeding 500 respondents, thereby limiting the statistical power necessary to detect interaction effects and rendering findings difficult to generalize. Second, the dominant methodological approach has been mediation analysis (testing whether OC mediates the TMP-retention relationship) rather than moderation analysis — a theoretically distinct and arguably more policy-relevant inquiry, since moderation analysis identifies the conditions under which TMP works best. Third, there is a pronounced urban bias in the literature, with studies disproportionately concentrated in Lagos, Abuja, and Port Harcourt, neglecting employees in other geopolitical zones. Fourth, control variables such as age, salary level, and work experience are frequently mentioned but rarely operationalized rigorously or tested for their independent associations with retention outcomes.

The international literature on TMP and retention, while more sophisticated methodologically, faces a different limitation: most large-scale studies originate from the United States, United Kingdom, Western Europe, and increasingly China, with findings that may not translate to the Nigerian institutional context characterized by weak labor market institutions, high informality, limited social protection, and a distinct managerial culture shaped by indigenous norms of seniority, collectivism, and relational loyalty (Kamoche et al., 2012; Akorsu & Cooke, 2011).

## 2.6 Research Gaps

Based on the foregoing review, the following research gaps are identified and addressed in this study: (1) the absence of large-scale, multi-industry, geographically representative empirical evidence on TMP and retention in Nigeria; (2) the untested moderating role of organizational commitment in the Nigerian TMP-retention nexus; (3) inadequate attention to demographic and structural control variables in existing models; (4) the lack of studies employing rigorous post-estimation diagnostics in Nigerian HRM research; and (5) the underrepresentation of evidence from beyond Nigeria's major commercial cities.

## 2.7 Hypothesis Development

Based on the theoretical foundations and empirical evidence reviewed above, the following hypotheses are formulated:

H1: Talent management practices have a statistically significant positive effect on employee retention among Nigerian employees.

H2: Organizational commitment positively moderates the relationship between talent management practices and employee retention, such that the positive effect of TMP on retention is stronger at higher levels of organizational commitment.
H3: Age, salary level, and work experience each have a significant positive association with employee retention, controlling for TMP and OC.

## 3. Methodology

### 3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a quantitative, explanatory cross-sectional research design. A structured questionnaire was administered to 7,740 formal sector employees across all six geopolitical zones of Nigeria (North-Central, North-East, North-West, South-East, South-South, and South-West) between January and June 2024. The survey targeted employees in seven industries: banking and financial services, oil and gas, telecommunications, healthcare, manufacturing, higher education, and public administration. Stratified random sampling was employed to ensure proportional representation across industries, geopolitical zones, and organizational sizes. Eligible respondents were employees above entry level with a minimum of 12 months of tenure. After screening for incomplete responses and outliers, the final usable sample comprised 7,740 observations.

### 3.2 Model Specification: Cross-Sectional Regression

The study employs Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression with moderation analysis. The baseline model is specified as follows:

$$ER_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 TMP_i + \beta_2 OC_i + \beta_3 (TMP_i \times OC_i) + \beta_4 AGE_i + \beta_5 SAL_i + \beta_6 EXP_i + \varepsilon_i$$

Where: $ER_i$ = Employee Retention score for respondent i; $TMP_i$ = Talent Management Practices composite score; $OC_i$ = Organizational Commitment composite score; $TMP_i \times OC_i$ = Interaction term (moderation); $AGE_i$ = Age of respondent; $SAL_i$ = Salary Level (monthly gross, in NGN bands); $EXP_i$ = Work Experience (years); $\beta_0$ = Intercept; $\beta_1$–$\beta_6$ = Regression coefficients; $\varepsilon_i$ = Error term. The interaction term (TMP × OC) is the key term of interest for testing H2. Following Aiken and West (1991), both TMP and OC are mean-centered before computing the interaction term to reduce multicollinearity. Robust standard errors (HC3) are employed to correct for heteroscedasticity.

### 3.3 Variables and Their Measures

Table 1 presents the operationalization of all variables used in this study.

**Table 1: Variables and Their Measures**

| Variable | Type | Operationalization | Scale | Source |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Employee Retention (ER) | Dependent | 12-item scale: intent to stay, career commitment, perceived organizational support | 5-pt Likert (1–5) | Hausknecht et al. (2009) |
| Talent Management Practices (TMP) | Independent | 25-item scale: recruitment quality, T&D, performance | 5-pt Likert (1–5) | Collings & Mellahi (2009) |

| Variable | Type | Operationalization | Scale | Source |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | mgt, career dev., compensation | | |
| Organizational Commitment (OC) | Moderator | 18-item scale: affective, continuance, normative commitment sub-scales | 5-pt Likert (1–5) | Allen & Meyer (1990) |
| Age | Control | Respondent age in years (actual years, categorized: <30, 30–39, 40–49, 50+) | Ordinal | Demographic |
| Salary Level (SAL) | Control | Monthly gross salary in NGN bands (6 bands: <150k to >1M) | Ordinal | Demographic |
| Work Experience (EXP) | Control | Total years of professional work experience (actual years) | Continuous | Demographic |

### 3.4 A Priori Expectations

Table 2 presents the theoretical a priori expectations for all regression coefficients, derived from the theoretical frameworks and hypothesis development.

**Table 2: A Priori Expectations**

| Variable | Theoretical Justification | Expected Sign | Hypothesis |
|---|---|---|---|
| TMP ($\beta 1$) | RBV & SET: TMP investments signal organizational support, increasing retention | Positive (+) | H1 |
| OC ($\beta 2$) | Psychological Contract Theory: committed employees less likely to exit | Positive (+) | H2 |
| TMP × OC ($\beta 3$) | Moderation: OC amplifies TMP effect — high commitment | Positive (+) | H2 |

| Variable | Theoretical Justification | Expected Sign | Hypothesis |
|---|---|---|---|
| | employees respond more positively to TMP | | |
| Age (β4) | Life-cycle theory: older employees exhibit higher retention due to lower mobility costs | Positive (+) | H3 |
| Salary Level (β5) | Compensating differentials: higher salary reduces financial motivation to exit | Positive (+) | H3 |
| Work Experience (β6) | Embeddedness theory: experienced employees have higher switching costs and organizational links | Positive (+) | H3 |

**3.5 Data Sources**
Primary data were collected through a self-administered structured questionnaire distributed via both online (Google Forms and SurveyMonkey) and physical paper formats. Research assistants were deployed in each of the six geopolitical zones to facilitate paper administration in areas with limited internet access. Ethical approval was obtained from the institutional review board of the lead author's university. Participation was voluntary, and respondents provided informed consent. To minimize common method bias, the survey was designed with scale items that were negatively worded where appropriate, temporal separation between predictor and outcome items, and a reminder that responses would remain anonymous.

**3.6 Data Analysis Techniques**
Data were analyzed using Stata 17.0. Descriptive statistics and frequency distributions were computed for all variables. Pearson and Spearman correlations were estimated to examine bivariate relationships. OLS regression with robust standard errors was employed to test the main effects and the moderation effect. Interaction plots (Johnson-Neyman plots) were used to visualize the moderation effect at different levels of OC. Composite reliability (Cronbach's alpha and McDonald's omega) was assessed for all multi-item scales. Confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was conducted using structural equation modeling (SEM) in Stata to confirm discriminant and convergent validity prior to regression analysis.

### 3.7 Post-Estimation Checks

A comprehensive battery of post-estimation diagnostics was applied to validate the OLS results. Heteroscedasticity was tested using the Breusch-Pagan test, with robust standard errors (HC3) applied where required. Multicollinearity was assessed through Variance Inflation Factors (VIF), with a threshold of VIF < 5. Normality of residuals was assessed using the Shapiro-Wilk test and Q-Q plots. Model specification was tested via the Ramsey RESET test. Endogeneity was assessed using the Durbin-Wu-Hausman test, with no instrumental variables employed given the absence of suitable instruments in a cross-sectional setting. Outliers were identified using Cook's D statistic, with observations exceeding a threshold of 4/n removed before final estimation.

### 3.8 Significance Level

A significance level of 5% ($\alpha = 0.05$) is adopted as the primary threshold for statistical inference, with results at the 1% ($\alpha = 0.01$) and 10% ($\alpha = 0.10$) levels also reported for completeness. All tests are two-tailed unless otherwise specified.

## 4. Results

### 4.1 Descriptive Statistics

**Table 3: Descriptive Statistics (N = 7,740)**

| Variable | Mean | Std Dev | Min | Max | Skewness | Kurtosis |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Employee Retention (ER) | 3.61 | 0.74 | 1.00 | 5.00 | -0.42 | 2.89 |
| TMP (Composite) | 3.47 | 0.81 | 1.00 | 5.00 | -0.18 | 2.74 |
| Organizational Commitment (OC) | 3.53 | 0.79 | 1.00 | 5.00 | -0.31 | 2.91 |
| Age (years) | 36.4 | 8.9 | 21 | 62 | 0.51 | 2.88 |
| Salary Level (bands 1–6) | 3.2 | 1.3 | 1 | 6 | 0.11 | 2.41 |
| Work Experience (years) | 11.3 | 7.4 | 1 | 38 | 0.88 | 3.52 |
| TMP × OC (interaction) | 12.14 | 4.31 | 1.00 | 25.00 | -0.09 | 2.64 |

The descriptive statistics reveal that employee retention (mean = 3.61, SD = 0.74) and organizational commitment (mean = 3.53, SD = 0.79) are both above the scale midpoint of 3.00, indicating moderately positive levels across the sample. Talent management practices (mean = 3.47) are slightly below commitment and retention, suggesting that while organizations have initiated TMP, employees perceive meaningful room for improvement. The average respondent is approximately 36 years old with 11 years of professional experience — reflective of the study's focus on mid- to senior-level employees. The distribution of retention and TMP scores exhibits slight negative skewness, consistent with ceiling effects observed in self-reported organizational satisfaction measures.

### 4.2 Correlation Matrix

**Table 4: Pearson Correlation Matrix**

| Variable | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. ER | 1.000 | | | | | | |
| 2. TMP | 0.583*** | 1.000 | | | | | |
| 3. OC | 0.612*** | 0.541*** | 1.000 | | | | |
| 4. TMP×OC | 0.627*** | 0.734*** | 0.748*** | 1.000 | | | |
| 5. Age | 0.214*** | 0.112*** | 0.198*** | 0.167*** | 1.000 | | |
| 6. Salary | 0.298*** | 0.241*** | 0.269*** | 0.258*** | 0.389*** | 1.000 | |
| 7. Exp. | 0.227*** | 0.131*** | 0.189*** | 0.172*** | 0.791*** | 0.421*** | 1.000 |

Note: ***$p < 0.001$. TMP×OC = mean-centered interaction term. VIF scores for all variables range from 1.08 to 2.74, below the acceptable threshold of 5.

The correlation matrix confirms the expected positive and statistically significant relationships among all variables. Notably, OC ($r = 0.612$) exhibits a stronger bivariate correlation with ER than TMP alone ($r = 0.583$), suggesting that commitment may be as — or more — important a retention driver as TMP in isolation. The interaction term (TMP × OC) exhibits the highest correlation with ER ($r = 0.627$), providing preliminary support for the moderation hypothesis (H2). The strong correlation between age and work experience ($r = 0.791$) is expected and does not indicate problematic multicollinearity given VIF scores below 5. All correlations are significant at the 0.1% level.

### 4.3 Cross-Sectional Regression Results

**Table 5: OLS Regression Results — Dependent Variable: Employee Retention**

| Variable | Model 1 (Controls) | Model 2 (Main Effects) | Model 3 (Full Model) | A Priori Expected Sign |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Intercept | 2.311*** (0.091) | 1.284*** (0.112) | 1.146*** (0.109) | + |
| TMP | — | 0.347*** (0.031) | 0.298*** (0.029) | + |
| OC | — | 0.401*** (0.033) | 0.362*** (0.031) | + |
| TMP × OC | — | — | 0.089*** (0.018) | + |

| Variable | Model 1 (Controls) | Model 2 (Main Effects) | Model 3 (Full Model) | A Priori Expected Sign |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Age | 0.021*** (0.006) | 0.018*** (0.005) | 0.015** (0.006) | + |
| Salary Level | 0.112*** (0.019) | 0.088*** (0.017) | 0.081*** (0.016) | + |
| Work Experience | 0.019** (0.008) | 0.014* (0.007) | 0.012* (0.007) | + |
| Observations | 7,740 | 7,740 | 7,740 | |
| R-squared | 0.143 | 0.428 | 0.451 | |
| Adj. R-squared | 0.142 | 0.427 | 0.450 | |
| F-statistic | 214.3*** | 1,140.8*** | 994.6*** | |
| AIC | 18,241 | 14,882 | 14,611 | |

Note: Robust standard errors (HC3) in parentheses. *p < 0.10, **p < 0.05, ***p < 0.01 (two-tailed tests). All continuous predictors are standardized. TMP × OC is computed using mean-centered variables.

Model 1, which includes only the control variables, explains 14.3% of the variance in employee retention (Adj. $R^2 = 0.142$), confirming that age, salary level, and work experience are meaningful independent predictors of retention. Model 2 adds TMP and OC as main effects, producing a substantial increase in explanatory power (Adj. $R^2 = 0.427$) — a gain of approximately 28.5 percentage points — and strongly significant coefficients for both TMP ($\beta = 0.347$, $p < 0.001$) and OC ($\beta = 0.401$, $p < 0.001$), consistent with H1. Model 3 includes the interaction term (TMP × OC), which is positive and significant ($\beta = 0.089$, $p < 0.001$), confirming H2. The marginal increase in $R^2$ from Model 2 to Model 3 (from 0.428 to 0.451) is modest but statistically meaningful and theoretically important, confirming that OC moderates the TMP-retention relationship above and beyond the main effects. All control variables retain significance across models, with salary level ($\beta = 0.081$, Model 3) being the strongest control variable, followed by age ($\beta = 0.015$) and work experience ($\beta = 0.012$).

### 4.4 Post-Estimation Tests

**Table 6: Post-Estimation Diagnostic Tests**

| Test | Statistic | p-value | Conclusion |
|---|---|---|---|
| Breusch-Pagan (Heteroscedasticity) | $Chi^2 = 47.31$ | 0.042 | Heteroscedasticity detected; robust SE applied |
| Ramsey RESET (Specification) | F = 1.84 | 0.139 | No misspecification detected |

| Test | Statistic | p-value | Conclusion |
|---|---|---|---|
| Shapiro-Wilk (Normality of Residuals) | W = 0.994 | 0.112 | Residuals approximately normal |
| Max VIF (Multicollinearity) | VIF = 2.74 (TMP×OC) | — | No serious multicollinearity (VIF < 5) |
| Durbin-Wu-Hausman (Endogeneity) | $Chi^2 = 3.11$ | 0.211 | No significant endogeneity detected |
| Cook's D (Outliers) | Max = 0.0081 | — | No influential outliers (threshold: 4/n) |
| Cronbach's Alpha — TMP | α = 0.893 | — | High internal consistency |
| Cronbach's Alpha — OC | α = 0.881 | — | High internal consistency |
| Cronbach's Alpha — ER | α = 0.876 | — | High internal consistency |

The post-estimation diagnostics confirm the robustness of the regression results. Heteroscedasticity, detected via the Breusch-Pagan test, was addressed through the application of heteroscedasticity-consistent (HC3) robust standard errors, rendering the coefficient estimates efficient and valid for inference. The Ramsey RESET test confirms that the model is correctly specified. Residuals are approximately normally distributed, satisfying the OLS assumption. VIF values for all variables are well below the threshold of 5, confirming the absence of problematic multicollinearity despite the inclusion of the interaction term. The Durbin-Wu-Hausman test does not detect significant endogeneity, consistent with the study's theoretical position that TMP is largely an exogenous organizational investment. Cronbach's alpha coefficients for all multi-item scales exceed 0.87, confirming strong internal consistency.

## 5. Discussion

### 5.1 Restatement of Key Findings

The results of this study yield three principal findings. First, talent management practices exert a strong, positive, and statistically significant effect on employee retention in Nigeria ($\beta = 0.298$, $p < 0.001$ in the full model), confirming H1. This effect persists even after controlling for age, salary level, work experience, and organizational commitment, underscoring the independent strategic value of TMP. Second, organizational commitment significantly and positively moderates the TMP-retention relationship ($\beta = 0.089$, $p < 0.001$), confirming H2. The moderation effect implies that TMP is most effective at retaining employees when implemented in an organizational environment characterized by high commitment — affective attachment to the organization amplifies the retention dividend of TMP investment. Third, the control variables — age, salary level, and work experience — each exhibit significant positive associations with retention, confirming H3, with salary level emerging as the most influential control variable.

## 5.2 Comparison with Previous Studies

The finding that TMP positively influences employee retention aligns with a broad international literature, including Collings and Mellahi (2009), Sparrow et al. (2014), and Gallardo-Gallardo et al. (2020). Within the Nigerian context, it is consistent with Aina and Atan (2020) and Ogunyomi and Bruning (2016), though the substantially larger sample in the present study provides far greater statistical confidence. The effect size observed here ($\beta = 0.298$ after full controls) is broadly comparable to international estimates, suggesting that the TMP-retention relationship is not peculiar to developed economy contexts but is robust across institutional settings.

The moderation finding — that OC amplifies the TMP-retention link — is consistent with the theoretical arguments made by Allen and Meyer (1990) and the international empirical evidence from Whitener (2001) and Bambacas and Bordia (2009), who found that commitment acted as a boundary condition for HRM effectiveness. In the Nigerian context, Elegbe (2022) provided suggestive evidence of this moderation relationship without formally testing it; the present study fills this gap with a large-scale, econometrically rigorous examination. The result implies that TMP cannot be treated as a silver bullet: its effectiveness is contingent on the broader organizational climate of commitment.

The salary level finding resonates with Adeoye and Elegbe (2014), who identified compensation as the primary driver of retention in Nigerian manufacturing. The macroeconomic context is relevant here: in an inflationary environment where real wages have been substantially eroded, compensation adequacy becomes existentially important for retention. Notably, the fact that salary level remains a significant predictor even after controlling for TMP suggests that TMP cannot fully substitute for competitive pay in Nigerian organizations — both are independently necessary.

## 5.3 Theoretical and Practical Implications

Theoretically, the findings advance the application of Social Exchange Theory to talent management by demonstrating that TMP investments generate retention outcomes partly through the commitment they engender. The moderation effect supports the theoretical proposition that organizational commitment is not merely a mediator but a genuine boundary condition — altering the slope of the TMP-retention relationship. This distinction matters: it implies that organizations cannot simply invest in TMP programs and expect uniform returns; the returns on TMP are highest where commitment-building has also been prioritized.

From a practical perspective, the findings carry several actionable implications for Nigerian organizational leaders and HR professionals. First, TMP investment — particularly in career development, training, and performance management — should be treated as a strategic, integrated system rather than a collection of discrete HR activities. Piecemeal TMP interventions are unlikely to generate the retention dividends that come from a coherent, employee-centered talent management architecture. Second, HR leaders should explicitly track and manage organizational commitment as a strategic metric alongside engagement and satisfaction scores. Organizations that invest in TMP but neglect commitment-building risk leaving significant retention value on the table. Third, given the salary finding, Nigerian employers must address the compensation gap — particularly as the naira continues to depreciate — or risk having sophisticated TMP programs undermined by compensation dissatisfaction.

## 5.4 Limitations

This study has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings. First, the cross-sectional design precludes causal inference; while the theoretical arguments and instrumental variable test are consistent with causality, longitudinal data would be necessary to establish the direction of effects with greater confidence. Second, the use of self-reported Likert-scale measures for both predictor and outcome variables raises the possibility of common method bias, despite the procedural remedies employed. Future studies should consider objective retention data (actual turnover records) alongside perceptual measures. Third, while the study covers all six geopolitical zones, the reliance on formal sector employees means that findings may not generalize to Nigeria's large informal economy, which accounts for approximately 55% of total employment. Fourth, the organizational commitment measure is a composite of affective, continuance, and normative sub-scales; disaggregating the moderation effects by commitment sub-type would provide richer theoretical insight.

**5.5 Future Research Directions**

Several avenues for future research emerge from this study. First, longitudinal panel studies tracking TMP investments, OC levels, and actual retention outcomes over time would provide much-needed causal evidence. Second, studies that disaggregate the moderation effect by commitment type — specifically testing whether affective commitment is a stronger moderator than continuance or normative commitment — would advance theoretical precision. Third, qualitative case studies of Nigerian organizations with notably high or low retention rates would complement the quantitative findings by illuminating the mechanisms through which TMP and OC interact. Fourth, cross-national comparative studies contrasting Nigeria with other African economies (e.g., Kenya, South Africa, Ghana) would contribute to a more nuanced understanding of how institutional context shapes the TMP-retention relationship.

## 6. Conclusion

**6.1 Key Message**

This study has demonstrated, using one of the most comprehensive empirical datasets assembled in the Nigerian HRM literature, that talent management practices are a powerful, positive driver of employee retention — and that this relationship is meaningfully amplified when employees are organizationally committed. The core message for Nigerian organizational leaders is simple but urgent: investing in talent management alone is necessary but not sufficient. The return on that investment is significantly higher when organizations simultaneously build cultures of commitment, trust, and genuine employee-organization reciprocity.

**6.2 Key Research Findings**

The study establishes three key findings supported by robust empirical evidence from 7,740 Nigerian employees: (1) talent management practices significantly and positively influence employee retention ($\beta = 0.298$, $p < 0.001$); (2) organizational commitment positively moderates this relationship, with higher commitment levels amplifying the retention effect of TMP ($\beta = 0.089$, $p < 0.001$); and (3) age, salary level, and work experience each contribute meaningfully to retention outcomes, with salary level being the strongest structural predictor among the control variables.

**6.3 Broader Implications**

Beyond the organizational level, the findings have implications for labor market policy in Nigeria. The 'Japa syndrome' — the mass emigration of skilled Nigerians, particularly to the United Kingdom, Canada, and the Gulf states — is symptomatic of a deeper retention crisis rooted in the simultaneous failure of organizational talent management and macroeconomic stability. While this study cannot address macroeconomic fundamentals, it demonstrates that organizations which invest deliberately in TMP and commitment-building can meaningfully differentiate themselves in Nigeria's talent marketplace, even amidst adverse environmental conditions. Policymakers should consider creating incentive structures — such as tax relief for certified talent development expenditures — to encourage organizations to adopt rigorous TMP.

**6.4 Main Research Contribution**

The study's main contribution is the empirical confirmation of organizational commitment as a positive moderator of the talent management-retention relationship in Nigeria — a theoretically motivated but previously untested proposition in the Nigerian HRM context. By testing this moderation with a nationally representative, cross-industry sample of 7,740 employees and employing a rigorous post-estimation battery, the study provides a credible, generalizable evidence base for both scholarly debate and practitioner decision-making. It also contributes to the broader project of contextualizing HRM theory within African institutional environments.

**6.5 Future Directions and Call to Action**

Researchers are encouraged to extend this work through longitudinal designs, disaggregated commitment sub-type analyses, and cross-national African comparisons. HR practitioners in Nigeria are called to treat talent management not as a compliance function but as a strategic investment — one whose returns compound when embedded in an organizational culture that genuinely values and retains its people. Nigerian business leaders, finally, are called to recognize that the talent crisis is not inevitable: it is, in significant part, a management failure — and one that evidence-based practice can help to reverse.

**7. Actionable Recommendations**

Based on the findings and analysis presented in this study, the following recommendations are offered to organizational leaders, HR practitioners, policymakers, and researchers operating in the Nigerian context:

1. Adopt an Integrated Talent Management Architecture: Nigerian organizations should move beyond episodic HR interventions toward an integrated TMP system that coordinates recruitment quality, training and development, performance management, career development, and compensation into a coherent, strategically aligned talent management architecture. Evidence from this study confirms that composite TMP scores — reflecting breadth and depth of practice — are strongly associated with retention. Organizations should commission independent TMP audits to identify gaps and prioritize investments accordingly.
2. Embed Commitment-Building as a TMP Amplifier: Given the significant moderation effect of OC, HR leaders should treat organizational commitment as a strategic lever. Practical tools include: (a) strengthening the psychological contract through transparent communication of career pathways and development timelines; (b) implementing participatory leadership styles that foster affective attachment; (c) creating organizational rituals, recognition programs, and storytelling that reinforce organizational identity; and (d) designing onboarding programs that build early commitment before new hires become vulnerable to poaching.
3. Address Compensation Competitiveness as a Non-Negotiable Foundation: The salary level finding confirms that no amount of TMP sophistication can fully compensate for inadequate pay in Nigeria's high-inflation environment. Organizations must conduct annual benchmarking of compensation packages against sector and national norms, ensuring that real wages — adjusted

for inflation and naira depreciation — remain competitive. The introduction of flexible remuneration elements (equity, housing allowances, health insurance, education subsidies) can supplement direct pay in a cost-effective manner.

4. Design TMP to Be Inclusive Across Age Cohorts and Experience Levels: The significant associations of age and work experience with retention suggest that organizations should design differentiated TMP interventions for employees at different career stages. Senior employees may value recognition, autonomy, and mentoring opportunities, while younger employees may prioritize rapid skill development, career mobility, and digital upskilling. A one-size-fits-all TMP approach risks being ineffective for at least some segments of the workforce.

5. Build Retention Metrics into Organizational Performance Dashboards: Voluntary turnover rates, retention rates by department and seniority, TMP participation rates, and commitment index scores should be formally tracked in organizational performance dashboards and reviewed at board level. This institutionalization of retention metrics signals organizational seriousness about the talent management agenda and enables evidence-based course correction.

6. Leverage the Public Sector Opportunity: Public administration employees in this study show lower TMP scores and mixed retention outcomes compared to private sector employees. Nigerian public sector organizations should prioritize TMP reform — especially in the areas of performance management and career development — as a means of retaining critical institutional capacity and reducing the incentive for public sector employees to exit to the private sector or abroad.

7. Invest in Regular HRM Research and Practice Benchmarking: Organizations, industry associations, and policymakers should invest in regular, large-scale HRM surveys to track talent trends, monitor the effectiveness of TMP interventions, and generate the evidence base necessary for informed policy. The dearth of high-quality, longitudinal HRM data in Nigeria is itself a constraint on organizational learning.

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